

ONLINE COMMUNITIES

- An online community is a group of people with a shared common interest who communicate online.
 - People use online communities to socialise, share information, play games, work, learn and create.
 - Each type of online community has a function (what it does for people who use it) and features (which enable or allow it to achieve its function).
 - Features that provide the function of one type of community now could be used for other types of community in the future, because the internet and its uses are always evolving.
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Learning Objectives

- **Understand key features of online communities:**
 - social networking
 - online gaming
 - online work spaces
 - virtual learning environments (VLE)
 - user-generated reference sites: wikis, websites, forums
 - user-generated content: video sharing sites, blogs, websites
 - social bookmarking
 - **Know the functions and target audience** of different forms of online communities.
 - **Understand the ways** in which online communities are used to communicate and collaborate on a global scale.
 - **Be aware of the purpose** of responsible use and acceptable behaviour policies.
 - **Understand how to stay safe online:** cyber bullying, anonymity of others (misrepresentation), disclosure of personal information/location.
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Social Networking Communities

- **Function:** Online social network communities allow members to connect through shared interests or relationships. Examples include Facebook, Baidu® and Twitter.
- **Platform Convergence:** These communities include professional networks (LinkedIn®) and personal networks (Facebook). These different types of network started out with separate functions. However, the features and use of different types of social networks are starting to mix together. Personal networks are now used by professionals and businesses as well as for personal relationships.

Features list:

- **Profiles:** a collection of information about a user. Users can add information about themselves. Some services allow members to decide which info should be public, visible only to certain people, or invisible to anyone. Profiles can be personalised and include:
 - biographical details (name, gender, date of birth, location, language)
 - short 'about you' description
 - details about work and education
 - travel history
 - family details (relationship status, family members, pets)
 - contact info (telephone number, email address, website)
 - profile/background images, colour schemes, and designs.
- **Friend, follow and connect:** Features that allow users to add someone to their network. Some platforms restrict access to the full profile until a request is accepted, while others allow unrestricted access.
- **Stream, wall and timeline:** The place where posts from friends appear. It has changed how people communicate online, ensuring information is brought straight to the user rather than making the user look for it.
- **Status updates and posts:** Messages sent to other members in a network, publicly to all members, or to designated sub-groups.
- **Groups, lists and circles:** Allows creating named groups of members so posts are visible only to them (e.g., keeping family separate from work). Teams in organisations use this to communicate without sending info to everyone.
- **Tags:** Labels used to categorise content so other members can search for it.
- **User suggestions:** Suggests connections by analysing user interests, network interests, and friends of existing connections.
- **Reactions, ratings, likes, upvotes and downvotes:** Enables users to show reactions (liking or finding posts funny) or recommend posts. Downvotes show a dislike, though platforms try to avoid their negative message.
- **Share functionality:** Allows repeating others' posts to make them available to more people. A post that spreads widely far beyond its original network is described as 'viral'.
- **Comments and quotes:** Functional tools for members to write comments, facilitating online conversations.
- **Third-party integration:** Direct links on websites allowing people to share information to social networks easily.
- **Add content to posts:** Adding photos, videos, and URLs, with a preview tool before publishing.
- **Private or direct messages:** Allows sending private messages rather than posting publicly.
- **Notifications:** Alerts telling members about new interactions or content to keep them involved.
- **Analytics:** Services showing information about how people reacted to posts, helping users/organisations increase network size and followers.

Business and Monetization:

- **The Revenue Question:** Networks are often free to use, but their real cost depends on the value placed on personal information and how it is traded.
 - **Targeted Marketing Mechanism:** Platforms collect a huge amount of self-posted info, store it in databases, and analyse it. They sell this data to advertisers so they can target relevant sponsored posts to matched members.
 - **Promoted Posts:** Members pay a fee to elevate their posts. Targeted marketing allows organisations to aim promotions at matching attributes (e.g., specific age groups or genders) at the top of users' streams.
 - **Sponsored Posts:** Posts appearing at the top of all members' streams that do not use profile data for targeting.
 - **Market Scale:** As more members engage, organizations are more likely to pay for promotions because it provides a bigger market.
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Online Gaming Communities

- **Function:** Exist in order to allow members of the community to play multiplayer games together. Examples include PlayStation Network, Xbox Live, Steam®, and MMORPGs.
 - **Features list:**
 - links to social media
 - user profiles
 - information that allows users to find out how to complete games
 - experience points tracked and displayed on profiles, allowing users to choose to compete against others based on experience levels
 - discussion boards and forums to discuss tactics
 - statuses showing if other members are online
 - notifications about in-game events.
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Online Work Spaces

- **Function:** Exist so that members of the community can collaborate together for the purposes of work. Examples include Adobe® Connect™, Slack®, Microsoft SharePoint®, and Workplace by Facebook.
- **Features list:**
 - cloud storage and web applications to work on documents via web browsers
 - comments left on documents for users to view and reply to
 - simultaneous multi-user document editing to develop files together
 - messaging systems for work discussions
 - shared calendars to view diaries and arrange meetings
 - shared contact lists
 - chat rooms to discuss work tasks
 - systems for booking resources (ICT equipment, meeting rooms, transport)

- virtual meeting spaces providing presentation viewing, VoIP communication, and video conferencing tools.
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Virtual Learning Environments (VLEs)

- **Function:** Used to allow students and teachers to use learning and assessment materials. Examples include Pearson Active Teach, Google Classroom™, Moodle™, Schoology®, and Blackboard®.
 - **Features and Behavior:** VLE features are very similar to online work spaces. Many look and work like social networking communities, but they do not aim to connect users with people outside their network.
 - **Core Toolsets:**
 - a wall or timeline containing posts by teachers and students
 - a notice board for course announcements
 - audio, video, web link, or file sharing tools
 - quizzes or multiple choice tests that are often graded automatically
 - assignment submission portals
 - teacher-moderated communication tools (forums, chat rooms, wikis, blogs)
 - third-party integration features
 - **Single Sign-On (SSO):** Links log-ins to school systems to sign students in automatically when on the institution's network
 - **Document editors:** For teachers to create, edit, and collaborate on files with students
 - **Gradebooks:** Methods to monitor progress through courses and tasks
 - **Access statistics:** Tracking tools for teachers to see how frequently students use VLE facilities.
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User-Generated Reference Sites

- Reference sites are information websites created and maintained by communities of members.

Wikis:

- **Function:** To allow members of the community to collaborate in order to build and edit web pages. Examples include Wikipedia and Discogs.
- **Features list:**
 - member accounts to track which edits were made by which members
 - an edit button taking editors directly to a text editor
 - structured language to format pages or add links
 - search tools.

Forums:

- **Function:** Provide members with online spaces for structured discussions arranged in topics or threads. Examples include Yahoo!®, Google Groups™, Stack Overflow®, Quora®, and The Student Room®.
 - **Features list:**
 - groups establishing different access rights for different members
 - **Moderators:** Members with the right to allow or block posts or members
 - **Administrators:** Members with moderator privileges plus rights to promote members to moderators and demote moderators
 - posts and date/topic sorted conversation threads
 - **Sticky notes (stickies):** Threads kept at the top of lists for easy access
 - user ratings to indicate helpful or genuine posts
 - private direct message functions (sometimes viewable by admins/moderators).
 - **Forum Safety Features:**
 - *Word or URL censoring:* Automated scanning software checks posts for inappropriate content; filters reject the post or send it to moderators.
 - *Ignore or block:* Features that mute members or stop forum access across the entire board.
 - *Rules and acceptable use policies:* Inform members of boundaries; violations result in private warnings or blocks.
 - *Report/flag user:* Allows members to report rule breakers to moderators.
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User-Generated Content Platforms

Video-Sharing and Photo-Sharing Sites:

- **Function:** Allow people to access and share content created and uploaded by members. Examples include Vimeo®, Flickr®, 500px, Giphy®, and YouTube®.
- **Features list:** User accounts/profiles, Content Management Systems (CMS) to add/edit page content, tags, ratings, comments, and third-party social networking links.

Blogs and Vlogs:

- **Function:** Allow people to create online diaries of events or articles. Examples include Weibo®, Wordpress®, Tumblr®, and YouTube.
 - **The Community Distinction:** Individual blogs or vlogs are only called communities if two or more authors collaborate to create and update them, or if they allow interaction between the blogger and their readers.
 - **Features list:** Accounts, online text editors, media upload tools, tags, ratings, comments, and social sharing options.
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Social Bookmarking Sites

- **Function:** Exist to allow people to share web documents and URLs with each other. Examples include Pinterest®, Digg®, Pocket™, reddit®, and StumbleUpon®.
 - **Features list:** Social networking features, third-party link integration buttons, categorization tags, and user accounts.
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ONLINE SAFETY & RISK PROTOCOLS

Anonymity and Misrepresentation

- Members can choose to stay anonymous online. Anonymity can protect users, but it also means some users can misrepresent themselves by pretending to be someone they are not.
- **The Safety Rule:** Make sure you know who you are talking to online. If you get to know someone online, never arrange to meet them in person on your own. If someone asks you to meet them, tell an adult whom you trust.

Personal Data and Location Disclosure

- Disclosing too much personal info is dangerous and can be exploited for grooming or to locate a person, their friends, and family.
- **Geotagging Leaks:** Location data can be given away, either on purpose or by accident, by uploading geotagged photographs to photo-sharing sites.
- **Mobile Tracking:** Community apps track coordinates via GPS data, Wi-Fi access points, or ISP data. If activated, any community member can find out exactly where that person is.
- **Defensive Actions:**
 1. Think carefully about how much personal information to make public.
 2. Do not post publicly any images containing location details.
 3. Check and update privacy settings regularly so only real-world contacts have access.
 4. Report anyone who is misrepresenting themselves or putting members at risk.

Cyberbullying

- Cyberbullying is the term used to describe the use of the internet to send text or images in order to upset or embarrass someone.
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Subject Vocabulary & General Vocabulary

- **online community**: a group of people with a shared common interest who communicate online
- **member**: someone who is part of an online community
- **profile**: a collection of information about a user
- **post (noun)**: a message sent to an internet discussion group so that all members of the group can read it
- **post (verb)**: to put a message or computer document on the internet so that other people can see it
- **targeted marketing**: advertising that is matched to internet users based on their attributes, such as their age group or their gender, or their internet browsing history
- **tag**: a label that you can add to a post
- **connections**: people or accounts to whom a user is connected
- **viral**: something that is circulated widely by being shared through networks to large numbers of internet users
- **notification**: an alert that tells a user about a new interaction or new content within a social networking community
- **analytics**: information that results from the analysis of data
- **Massively Multiplayer Online Role-playing Game (MMORPG)**: an online video game that allows large numbers of people to play together
- **multiplayer games**: games that are played by more than one person, usually online
- **experience points**: credits earned by a user for completing one part of a game
- **forum**: a website or web page where users can post comments and information and reply to other users' comments
- **cloud storage**: storage provided by servers that are connected to the internet
- **contact list**: a virtual address book that allows users to quickly access the contact details of friends and colleagues
- **chat room**: a place on the internet where users can write messages to other people and receive messages back from them immediately
- **virtual learning environments (VLEs)**: websites that contain teaching and learning tools
- **moderate**: decide whether content is appropriate; moderators decide whether posts should be removed or posted at all
- **single sign on (SSO)**: a system that allows users to log in once to access a number of related websites and systems
- **gradebook**: a virtual method of recording students' scores on assignments and tests
- **wiki**: a website or database that is developed by a number of collaborating users, all of whom can add and edit content
- **thread**: a series of messages concerning the same subject, written by members of an internet discussion group
- **blog (short for web log)**: a website or web page that is updated regularly, often written like a diary or a series of articles
- **vlog (short for video log)**: a video blog
- **blogger**: someone who creates or maintains a blog
- **social bookmarking**: using tags to categorise web documents and URLs so that other people can find content by using the tags in a search
- **geotag (verb)**: to add location data to a piece of content
- **professional**: someone who works in a job that needs special education and training, such as a doctor, lawyer or architect

- **promote**: publicise
 - **categorise**: to put things into groups or categories according to the type of thing that they are
 - **cluster**: a group of things that are arranged very close together
 - **preview**: see a document, page or film before it is produced in its final form and published
 - **tactics**: the methods used to achieve a goal
 - **demote**: make someone a lower rank or remove their privileges
 - **mute**: silence someone or something
 - **anonymous**: unidentified and unnamed
 - **anonymity**: the state of being anonymous; when other people do not know who you are or what your name is
 - **misrepresentation**: pretending to be someone or something that you are not
 - **in person**: face-to-face; in the real world
 - **disclose**: make information known to other people
 - **grooming**: pretending to befriend someone (often a child or young adult) with the intention of harming or abusing that person
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End of chapter questions

- 1 Which one of these activities is only possible when using the internet? (1)
 - A. Television
 - B. Radio
 - C. Streaming
 - D. Mobile telephone calls
 - 2 State two benefits to employees of working from home. (2)
 - 3 State two drawbacks to organisations of employees working from home. (2)
 - 4 Explain one reason why the use of the internet may affect the ability of individuals to interact with other people face-to-face. (3)
 - 5 Explain one reason why cyberbullying can be more distressing than in-person bullying. (2)
 - 6 State what is meant by the term 'collaborative working'. (1)
 - 7 State three factors that affect unequal access to ICT. (3)
 - 8 State three examples of services that are not available to those with limited or no access to digital technologies. (3)
 - 9 Describe two ways in which greater access to networks has affected society. (4)
 - 10 Describe the effect of the internet on the information gap. (2)
 - 11 Discuss the impact of the internet on how individuals socialise. (8)
 - 12 Describe two ways in which individuals can stay safe online. (4)
 - 13 Explain why organisations' use of the internet increases the risk to data security. (3)
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